

Sunshine Man

Driven by the desire to save trees, a Patna priest starts making solar appliances for everyday needs



KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

MATHEW AT HIS PLANT IN PATNA

By Amitabh Srivastava

Everyday at half-past-nine, Father Mathew settles down at the workshop in the St. Mary's Church campus of Phulwarisharif, Patna, where he stays till 5.30 p.m. His day is spent not dealing directly with the divine but monitoring and fine-tuning the manufacturing process of solar appliances. A Jesuit priest based in Patna, Mathew is worried about the dwindling forest cover in Bihar and his work is a means to tackle the ecological problem.

The 52-year-old diploma holder has established a solar appliances assembling unit with the help of German scientist Wolfgang Scheffler, who is regarded as the inventor of solar concentrated community cookers. Mathew has promoted these technologies to try and save trees that would otherwise have become firewood. "In fact the green cover across the country is under tremendous pressure as trees satiate both need and greed," he says. In the process, Mathew has gone much beyond the traditional definition of priesthood. His initiative was inspired by an earlier project called Taru

Mitra (friend of trees) that was set up by another priest, Father Robert Athickal. Taru Mitra was an initiative to convince people against chopping trees for firewood. Thanks to his training, Mathew knew what needed to be done. In 1996, he set up the solar appliances unit—Solar Alternatives & Associated Programmes (SAAP)—at Patna with just one welder and a few young men from his locality. The centre today provides employment to several youth.

The church chipped in with land and funding—Rs 1.25 lakh and a one-acre plot to set up the plant. Today, the centre produces a range of solar appliances, including solar steam turbines with reflectors that produce electricity using solar power, solar cookers and water heaters, and sterilisation units for hospitals. Orders have been pouring in from many states across the country. A majority of SAAP buyers are institutions like hostels, hospitals and hotels. With awareness about clean technologies building up, he is determined to bring sunshine to many more lives.